

Understanding ADHD Stimulant Medications

General guidance on stimulant medications used to treat ADHD in children, adolescents and adults, common effects, and monitoring needs.

What are stimulant medications used for?

Stimulant medications (such as methylphenidate or amphetamine-based medications) are first-line, highly effective treatments for ADHD in both children and adults, improving attention, impulse control and organization by increasing dopamine and norepinephrine activity in the brain.

What to expect

- Effects are usually noticeable within the first dose or two, unlike antidepressants which take weeks
- Your psychiatrist will adjust the dose and timing based on response and side effects
- Short-acting and long-acting (extended-release) formulations are available depending on your daily schedule

Common side effects

- Reduced appetite, particularly around dosing times
- Difficulty falling asleep if taken too late in the day
- Mild increase in heart rate or blood pressure
- Headache or mild irritability as the dose wears off

Important safety notes

- Blood pressure and heart rate are checked at the start of treatment and periodically

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- Report any chest pain, fainting, or significant mood changes to your psychiatrist
- These medications have misuse potential — take exactly as prescribed and store securely

When to seek urgent help

Seek urgent medical attention for chest pain, fainting, irregular heartbeat, or signs of a severe allergic reaction.

This material is for patient and family education only and does not replace individualized medical advice. For a personal diagnosis or treatment plan, consult Dr. Kushal Kharel or a qualified mental health professional.

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